

cover story SOCIETY CASE FILES

VICTIM: Jaswinder Kaur and son Robin Singh
ACCUSED: Husband Bhupinder Singh
CAUSE: SUSPICION OF AN AFFAIR

DATE: April 8, 2008

PLACE: Chandigarh

THE CASE: Bhupinder Singh, head constable with the Punjab Police, shot dead his wife and their 18-year-old son Robin Singh before killing himself. The police claim the 50-year-old was suspicious of his wife's extra-marital relationship.



Bhupinder

POLITICIANS

VICTIM: Madhumita Shukla
ACCUSED: Amarmani Tripathi and wife Madhumani

CAUSE: EXTRA-MARITAL AFFAIR

DATE: May 9, 2003

PLACE: Lucknow



Shukla

THE CASE: A pregnant Madhumita Shukla was murdered at the behest of Madhumani who opposed her husband, former minister Amarmani Tripathi's affair with the poetess. The CBI had arrested Amarmani after a DNA match with that of the foetus. Amarmani and his wife have been sentenced for life. The case is now in the high court.

VICTIM: Atmaram Gupta
ACCUSED: Councillor Sharda Jain and her brother Raj Kumar Jain
CAUSE: JEALOUSY

DATE: August 2002

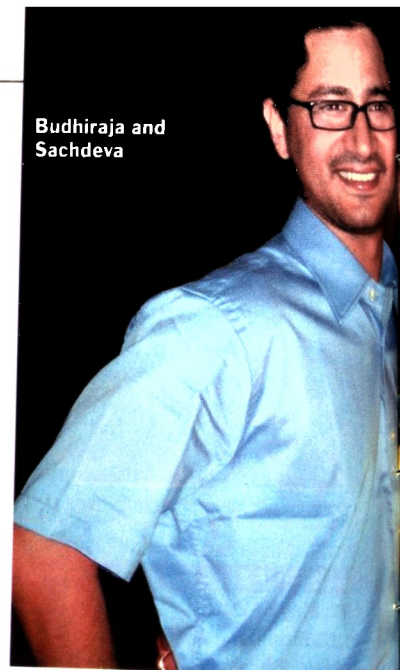
PLACE: Delhi

THE CASE: Former Delhi municipal councillor and Congress leader Sharda Jain, along with her brother Raj Kumar

significantly increased over the last decade. Not able to take a no for an answer from their ambitious girlfriends, who are dumping small town boys for a glamorous life in Mumbai, thwarted boyfriends are acting like Avinash Patnaik, who resorted to the extreme measure of killing his girlfriend Moon Das's mother and uncle as a retribution for rejection. While Indian women may have found financial independence, men are still conditioned to tame them sexually. Says Trupti Panchal, marriage counsellor and head of the Special Cell for Women and Children at Mumbai's Tata Institute of Social Service: "The expectation of fidelity and monogamy from women is absolute. She is seen as the property of the man." Adds Rajesh Gill, sociologist at Panjab University, Chandigarh: "As financially-independent women now have more opportunities for social networking outside marriage, husbands are on a shorter fuse against such discretion."

While the late 1990s were characterised by spiralling divorce rates, thanks to the financial independence women found, the 21st century is seeing a disturbing trend of rising promiscuity and crimes related to uncontrolled passion. According to a survey done by the Special Cell for Women and Children, 38 per cent cases of violence against women in Mumbai are directly to do with the suspicious nature of their husbands. In the past one year, there have been 15 cases of killing in Maharashtra due to a love triangle. Data compiled by the National Crime Records Bureau shows that love affairs and sexual causes are among the top three motives for all murders and culpable homicides committed in the country in 2006. In states like Punjab, Delhi, Gujarat, Maharashtra and Andhra Pradesh—where there is a high degree of urbanisation—love affairs and sexual causes are the top cause for murders. If it's not the unbridled desire for power and lust driving women to crime then it's the desire of men to bring women under their

Budhiraja and Sachdeva



control that is driving men to murder. Crimes of passion, according to Punjab Police authorities, have almost doubled in urban areas in the past five years. "As tolerance level has depleted alarmingly in upwardly mobile sections of society, mere suspicion about a woman's infidelity is provoking extreme violence," says Punjab DGP N.P.S. Aulakh.

The highlight of this trend is the murder of Rinku Sachdeva in Bangalore by her husband Amit Budhiraja, a software engineer with Infosys. He smothered her to death, after an argument over her alleged affair with a colleague. Budhiraja committed suicide after killing her. Sociologists discern a troubling trend. A 2007 study of violence against women in Punjab by the Institute of Development and Communication (IDC), a Chandigarh-based social policy think-tank, found that as many as 80 per cent husbands justified their use of force against their wives on the ground of her being "sexually unfaithful". In urban areas, 15 per cent husbands justified wife-bashing, accusing her of "loose character". Says Rainuka Dagar, direc-

"As tolerance level has depleted alarmingly in the upper strata of society, mere suspicion about a woman's infidelity is provoking extreme violence."

N.P.S. AULAKH, DGP, PUNJAB

